statement welcoming them. Our study of that message will shortly be completed and when it is I will be responding specifically to the points you made in it. Nancy joins me in saying our best regards to you and your wife.

Sincerely,
Ronald Reagan
February 6, 1986

Two weeks later, on Presidents' Day, while Nancy was away on a speaking trip in Texas, I decided to try again and sent Gorbachev a seven-page, handwritten letter with a set of new proposals that I hoped would bring the still-deadlocked Geneva talks off dead center while responding to his proposals. Below are excerpts from this letter:

I am encouraged that you have suggested steps leading toward a world free from nuclear weapons, even though my view regarding the steps necessary differs from yours in certain respects. However, having agreed on the objective and on the need for taking concrete steps to reach that goal, it should be easier to resolve differences in our viewpoints as to what these steps should be. Our initial moves are of course the essential ones to start this process and therefore I believe we should focus our negotiating efforts on them. Of course, if we are to move toward a world in which the eventual elimination of nuclear weapons will be possible, there must be far greater trust and confidence between our two countries than exist at present. We cannot simply wave away the suspicion and misunderstandings which have developed over the past four decades between our two countries. The process of reducing and eventually eliminating nuclear weapons can by itself nurture greater confidence and